

A Girl in Memory

The illusion of love powers this Bengali classic brimming with contemporary sensibilities



MY KIND OF GIRL
by BUDDHADEVA BOSE
Translated by
ARUNAVA SINHA
Random House
India
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| By Damayanti Datta |

Four middle-aged men, chance-directed, huddle together in the unwelcoming comfortlessness of a remote railway waiting room on a biting cold night. They don't know each other and have nothing in common. Except, the compulsion to spend the night together and the near certainty that beyond that night, their paths will not cross again. As the world outside gets obliterated in the dim light of that stark, dispassionate room and the blue smoke of their cigarettes, the strangers start spinning their never-told memories of "my kind of girl".

It's a book on love: the idea, the illusion, the fantasy and the impossibility. Although *Moner Moto Meye* was written way back in 1951 by Buddhadeva Bose, one of the greatest Bengali writers of the post-Tagore era, it brims with contemporary sensibilities. Nothing is spoken out loud, nothing is ever absolutely resolved, yet "unspoken" narratives create potent moments of love, longing and loss.

The "gaze" in the book is decidedly male, but never brazen or domineering. And the reflection on that mirror is always of a strong feminine spirit—sometimes remote and unyielding, sometimes passionate and intense, sometimes volatile and unpredictable, and often pure and childlike. The burly contractor, Makhanlal, had his head swirling with calculations of wood, steel, nails, bolts and his eyes peeled for the flash of a sari from the neighbouring verandah. Yet when he helped her family out of financial distress, the proud professor's daughter threw him out. Love remained unsaid, but the girl of his dreams became eternally real. Pakhi, married off, was woman enough to seal her unattainable love for Gagan Baran with a bold kiss, en route to her new husband. But it took the successful bureaucrat many years and a chance comment to realise, fleetingly, what love is. Dr Abani, though perfectly happy now, never fully understood if his wife's decision to marry him was born out of love or convenience right after a heartbreak. In the poet's tale, love came as a new mapping of consciousness, as three friends lost to death the girl they all loved. A fantasy image that the poet could aspire for all his life.

The credit for making this magical and totally entertaining volume accessible to a wider readership beyond the two Bengals and the Bangla-speaking diaspora goes to the translator Arunava Sinha. No mean task, given Bose's lean, lyrical and nuance-laced prose. Sinha has caught the dynamic and unfettered style admirably and verifies Bose's standing. ■

TOP 10

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FICTION

1. The Pillars of the Earth
Ken Follett, Signet
2. The White Tiger
Aravind Adiga, HarperCollins
3. The Story of My Assassins
Tarun J. Tejpal, HarperCollins India
4. The 3 Mistakes of My Life
Chetan Bhagat, Rupa
5. The Winner Stands Alone
Paulo Coelho, HarperCollins

NON-FICTION

1. Don't Lose Your Mind, Lose Your Weight
Rujuta Diwekar, Random House
2. A Better India, A Better World
N.R. Narayana Murthy, Allen Lane
3. Stay Hungry Stay Foolish
Rashmi Bansal, CIE, IIM-Ahmedabad
4. Outliers: The Story of Success
Malcolm Gladwell, Allen Lane
5. Imagining India: Ideas for the New Century
Nandan Nilekani, Allen Lane

OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

FICTION

6. Slumdog Millionaire
Vikas Swarup, Black Swan
9. Of Course I Love You... Till I Find Someone Better
Durjoy Datta and Maanvi Ahuja, Srishti
10. Five Point Someone
Chetan Bhagat, Rupa

NON-FICTION

6. Leadership in the Era of Economic Uncertainty
Ram Charan, TMH
7. BPO-Sutra: True Stories from Inside India's BPOs & Call Centres
Sudhindra Mokhasi, Rupa
13. Spiritual Parenting
Gopika Kapoor, Hay House

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